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ANGLO-AMERICAN CONVERSATIONS

The Prime Minister (Mr. Winston Churchill): I should myself have thought that it would have been more for the convenience of the House not to delay the important debate on the financial and economic situation which must follow on yesterday's statement by the Chancellor of the Exchequer and I should myself have liked to present my whole case, the whole case, to the House in its proper setting during the course, or at the opening, of the debate we are to have on foreign affairs next week. However, in deference to the wishes expressed by the Opposition, to which it is always my desire to concede every possible point, I will try to clear up a few points about the recent American visit of myself, my right hon. Friend and other Ministers in another place, and to deal with those points which, though not urgent, are the subject of misunderstanding or misrepresentation and have already figured upon the Order Paper of the House.

I was led to cross the Atlantic by my conviction that, in view of all that is going on in all continents, it was important for His Majesty's new Government to establish intimate and easy relations and understandings with the President and the governing authorities of the United States. I also thought it important to try to give the impression to the American people that we rejoice in their effort to defend the cause of world freedom against Communist aggression and penetration and that we will aid them in this purpose, which is also ours, with all our strength and goodwill.

My hon. Friend the Member for Morecambe and Lonsdale (Sir I. Fraser) asked me a Question on the Order Paper today about the Joint Atlantic Command. I remain unconvinced of the need for the appointment of a Supreme Commander and I think that the method adopted in the last war afforded the most practical foundation for maintaining the traffic across the Atlantic in time of war. I was, however, confronted with the agreements which had been made and announced during the term of the late Government and with the fact that these agreements could not be altered except by discussions in the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation. I felt it would be very unfortunate if a protracted argument arose between us and the United States in this wide audience, and I have therefore been forced to accept in principle the situation as it was left to me.

The House will be aware, however, from the communiqué which was issued after my last meeting with President Truman on 18th January that I was able in my discussions in Washington to introduce into the Atlantic Command proposals certain alterations which will provide great flexibility in the Command of the whole Atlantic sphere and will also ensure that there is the fullest co-operation between the Commanders-in-Chief of the Eastern Atlantic and the Home Station, both of whom will be British officers. The Commander-in-Chief of the Home Station will be directly responsible to the Admiralty for the safe arrival and the dispatch of the convoys upon which our survival and the survival of any armies in Europe which the United States may have sent necessarily depend.

As an example of the greater degree of flexibility achieved in our discussions, I may say that it has been arranged that the new Supreme Commander will send instructions to his area commanders which will enable them to support adjoining commands in operations throughout the Atlantic and in British home waters without constant reference to himself. Further, His Majesty's Government, with the full agreement of the United States, are putting forward to the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation an amendment to the existing command boundaries so as to extend our Home Command to the westward as far as the one-hundred-fathom line. The right hon. Gentleman will remember that I mentioned that to him at the beginning of this controversy many months ago. The one-hundred-fathom line has many advantages; among others, it broadly corresponds to the limits within which moored mining is profitable and was a very well-known feature in all our affairs in the war.

I can also state, subject to these amendments, that His Majesty's Government are prepared, in the interests of N.A.T.O. unity, to agree to the appointment within that organisation of an American Supreme Commander and a British Deputy Supreme Commander.

The choice of the officer whose name has been announced today, Admiral McCormick is one which should ensure the highest confidence among all members of the Atlantic Organisation.

I now come to the question of the war in Korea, the prolongation of the truce negotiations there, with the possibility of their break-down or breach after a settlement had been made, and the attitude we should adopt in that event towards the Chinese Communists whom we have recognised, but who have not entered into relations with us. As we all know on both sides of the House, we can recognise many people of whose conduct we do not entirely approve.

In discussing these matters, we must first of all bear in mind always, I think, the fact that the contribution by Britain and the British Commonwealth to the war in Korea is less than one-tenth of the forces employed; and while our losses, for which we grieve, have amounted in killed, wounded and missing, to nearly 3,000, similar American losses are over 105,000, or 35 or 40 times as great. So there should be no party differences on the reasons why we are in this war. It was entered upon by the late Government with our full support, and it is authorised and sustained by the United Nations.

I was most anxious, therefore, that we should make the United States Government feel that we meant to be their good comrades at the council board, as our Commonwealth Division and Naval and Air Forces have proved themselves to be in the field of action.

The House is aware that for six months negotiations for a truce have been going on between the United States and the Chinese Communist Government. We do not know whether the negotiations—[HON. MEMBERS: "The United Nations."]—what did I say?—[HON. MEMBERS: "The United States."]—between the United States on behalf of the United Nations—[HON. MEMBERS: "Hear, hear."]—we have a lot of things to quarrel about and we need not add to them—between the United Nations and the United States and the Chinese Government will be spun out indefinitely or whether a conclusion will be reached, or whether, after that conclusion has been reached, the Chinese Communists will break their engagement and take any advantages which might be open to them. Neither do we know whether a truce in Korea might not be reached only as a means of transferring Communist strength to the frontiers of French Indo-China or Malaya. This important aspect must be borne in mind.

The whole hypothetical question of what should be done, should a truce be made only to be broken, had been discussed before we left for America between the United Kingdom and the United States and the other Governments who have fighting forces in the field. It was agreed that clearly a very serious situation would arise in such an event as a breach of the truce; and various contingencies had been examined without any definite or formal commitments being entered into.

No change was made in the situation while we were in the United States. In fact, the matter did not figure to any large extent in our discussions. I do not feel it would be an advantage to go into the details of the discussions which took place before we left upon our voyage, those discussions about what we should do, or should not do, in the event, first of a truce being reached, and secondly of it being broken. It is not wise, when a war is going on, to tell everything always to everybody, including the enemy. I suppose I may call them the enemy—they are shooting our soldiers—but including, shall we say, the other side. I think they may sometimes be left with something to guess about.

I thought it better, therefore, when I was invited to address the American Congress—which I regarded as a very great honour for this House, one in which the Leader of the Opposition has also shared—to speak in general terms of the action we should take in the event of a breach of the truce, and I used the words, "prompt, resolute and effective." I do not believe they were bad words to use. Certainly, if one is dealing in general terms, they are better than "tardy, timid and fatuous." I certainly did not mean to suggest that the words, "prompt, resolute and effective" represented any new designs or decisions arrived at during our visit——

Mr. John Paton: May I ask the right hon. Gentleman—[*Interruption.*]—this is very important——

The Prime Minister: They do not represent any new decisions arrived at during our visit.

Mr. Paton: Or before, in the preliminary conversations?

The Prime Minister: I said there had been discussions, but there had been no final or definite commitment, and that is the position now.

Mr. Paton: A gentleman's agreement——

The Prime Minister: But they do express frankly and fully the spirit in which we shall face our difficulties together.

I will now turn to some of the larger issues which are in the background of all thought upon the Korean campaign. At the outset, 18 months ago, I was personally disquieted by seeing, as I told the House at the time, the attention and resources of the United States being diverted from the main danger in Europe to this far-distant peninsula in the China Seas. But we must recognise that the United Nations have gained authority by the fact that unprovoked aggression has been met by armed force, and that the rule of law which we seek to establish has not lacked either will-power or resources.

This is of extreme importance. The ruin of the League of Nations, out of which so many disasters came, was because this will-power was lacking. It is also a fact that the stimulus of the fighting in Korea has developed to a degree otherwise impossible the re-armament of the free world, and, above all, of the United States. As I said to Congress, "the balance of the world has been altered" by the decision of President Truman, with the approval of the United Nations, to make this bold American stroke against aggression, in support of which we have all followed.

At the same time, when the main dangers are so much nearer home, we do not want to see ourselves tied down or entangled in a war in Korea—still less in a war in China. That would indeed, as General Bradley so forcibly said,

"be the wrong war, in the wrong place, at the wrong time."

Mr. Sydney Silverman: And on the wrong side.

Hon. Members: Traitor!

The Prime Minister: That, I think, is a very candid revelation by the hon. Member that he thinks that we ought to be on the side of the Chinese Communists against the United Nations.

Mr. Silverman: I do not raise a point of order, which might have been prompted by some of the remarks which have been made by some hon. Members opposite—I do not think they are worth noticing—but I want to say to the right hon. Gentleman that what I intended to convey was, that in any war in China, the issue of which would be whether the present Government should remain in power or whether Chiang Kai-shek should replace it, which would be the inevitable result of our taking part in those circumstances in a war in China now, it would not merely be the wrong enemy, the wrong war, the wrong time and the wrong place; it would also, in my opinion, be the wrong side.

The Prime Minister: I did not refer to General Chiang Kai-shek. I remember a time in the war when he was one of the great heroes and held to be the representative of the new Asia, and when he inspired marked enthusiasm in the hon. Gentleman because of his strenuous efforts to separate India from the British Crown. But everyone has his day, and some days last longer than others. I am glad that the hon. Gentleman has indicated that he was referring only to an inter-Chinese question, because I do not wish to burden him with any further responsibility than he already bears.

Mr. Silverman: The right hon. Gentleman will bear in mind that this whole question is complicated by the fact that the United States of America still recognises Chiang Kai-shek as the Government of China, whereas we do not, and that, therefore, if this country were in these circumstances to find itself involved in an extension of the war to China, it would be a war in which one of the issues, and perhaps in many ways the most important issue, would be whether the Government of China recognised by the Government of the United States or the Government of China recognised by the Government of the United Kingdom would win. In such a war we should find ourselves ranged on the wrong side.

The Prime Minister: Of course, the hon. Gentleman is to be complimented upon the assiduity and attention with which he studies the daily newspapers; and many other Members of the House do the same. But no issue has arisen as to the question of employing General Chiang Kai-shek on the continent. What I have said and repeat is that he and those who fought with him against the Communists and have taken refuge upon the island of Formosa should not be invaded and massacred there while the United Nations Forces possess such overwhelming naval superiority.

I said "the wrong war, in the wrong place, at the wrong time." I entirely agree with those forcible remarks of General Omar Bradley. The facts are so serious that they ought not to be overlooked. There are, shall we say, the equivalent of 10 divisions, including a most important part of the American Army and our one Commonwealth division, in Korea, and we do not know how long they will have to stay there.

General Juin, the French General, said in his recent visit to the United States that but for the Communist attacks in Indo-China the French Army in Europe could be 10 divisions stronger. If those were at home, it would presumably enable France to take a more confident view about the development of a German army, which is of the utmost importance to the problem. However, let us count the diminution of the French Army in Europe as 10 divisions; that is certainly a moderate estimate.

Then there are the British Forces which are spread about the East and Far East resisting Communist menace or other forms of Communist-inspired disorder, in Hong Kong, in Malaya and to some extent in the Canal Zone of the Middle East. These amount to at least six divisions, far more costly in resources to maintain than if they were at home or in Europe.

This makes a numerical total of 26 divisions, but the equivalent in war power measured by divisions employed in Europe might well be 30 or even 35. And all this is withdrawn from the European front, where the Atlantic Treaty Powers have so far only been able to deploy—that is a better word than concentrate—on this enormous front a very much smaller force. But for these pressures and assaults in the Far East, in South East Asia and the Middle East, forces would exist to form a front in Europe against what are called the 176 Soviet divisions of which we have been given timely warning by the former Minister of Defence, an enormous force far superior to anything we have. I think those divisions are not numerically comparable to the United Nations divisions or the Atlantic Treaty divisions but they are far superior in total.

If we had 50 divisions deployed to protect the civilisation of Europe, including Germany, at the present time, as we should have but for the ones which are detached all over the world, the Atlantic Treaty Powers would not be forced, as they are now, to rely so disproportionately on the immense and ever-growing American superiority in the atomic bomb, and there would be a chance of establishing a calmer atmosphere, and those conditions might well lead, if we were blessed by heaven, to at least a make-shift settlement lasting perhaps for a good many years.

But the men in the Kremlin, who have many anxieties of their own to face, may at any rate at this moment compliment themselves not only on having subjugated or brought into their Communist grip half Europe and all China, but on having pegged down in far-distant areas around the globe a much greater force than the Atlantic Powers have so far been able to gather to defend the civilisation of the West; and they may pride themselves on the fact that they have done all this without losing a single soldier in Russian uniform.

I leave this sombre spectacle, which I feel it is absolutely necessary to place before the House: actions and words cannot be judged except in relation to what is always the uppermost feeling in one's mind—anxiety. I leave this spectacle to return to the Korean front.

I do not think we have gained security during this long period of haggling and wrangling which has gone on at Panmunjom. Apart from anything else, the Chinese Communist Government, whose troops were being slaughtered at the rate of about 40 to 1 by the United Nations Forces, and who had a terrible mass of wounded and invalids flung back upon them far beyond their resources to handle, have, since the Soviet suggestion of a

[THE PRIME MINISTER.]

cease-fire and truce negotiations, re-established what is called their "face." That, I believe, is a technical term, a term of art which has great vogue in China, and they have since been bargaining all this time on equal terms with the representatives of the United Nations.

We still hope that an agreement will be reached. We still hope that, being reached, it will be kept. I think we have secured a better chance for the reaching of an agreement by making it plain that the United States and Britain are working together in true comradeship, and that in the event of a treacherous renewal of the war they will together take "prompt, resolute and effective action."

We have improved the chances of a settlement and limited the risks of a spread by making this declaration instead of giving the impression that we were disunited and taking small points off one another. I am sure that the way to play into the hands of those who direct the Communist menace from the centre would be to magnify differences between Britain and the United States and that nothing would be more likely than that to lead to renewal on a larger scale of the local war in Korea.

My own thoughts are never long absent from the European front and I was, therefore, very glad to have the opportunity in Washington of making it clear that the English-speaking world are acting together in true loyalty and unity and are resolved to bring the local events in the Far East into their proper relationship to our predominating danger in Europe.

Apart from the turmoil in the Far East and in South-East Asia, there are the troubles in the Middle East and Egypt. I have never had the feeling that we should make a bargain with the United States that if we worked smoothly with them in the Far East they should do the same for us in the Middle East. I think this should not be the subject of a bargain. Both cases should be dealt with on their merits, and both cases are pretty strong when looked at on their merits. It is certain that if Britain and the United States are known to be acting together, the difficulties will by that very fact be substantially reduced and the possibilities of peaceful arrangements will be greatly strengthened.

It is certain also that the main interest of the Communist oligarchy in the Kremlin is to provoke or at least to suggest divergencies between us. That, I think, should not be overlooked even in our debates in this House. On the other hand, the fact of simultaneous or concerted action between us and the United States becoming apparent will be beneficial to both of us and even more beneficial to the free world as a whole.

No more hopeful course has yet been suggested for the Middle East than the approach to all its problems in the spirit of the Four Power proposals. This was the policy of the late Government, for which they deserve the fullest credit, and we have given it immediate, cordial, sustained and determined support. Now that we no longer have available the former Imperial armies which existed in India, the burden of maintaining the control and security of the international waterway of the Suez Canal is one which must be more widely shared.

It is upon an international basis that the most hopeful solution of our Middle Eastern difficulties will be reached, and I trust that all the Powers concerned will play their part, working together and sharing the burden and responsibilities for the peace and security of the Middle East. It may be some time before that is achieved, but that should clearly be our aim and goal.

I have today been able only to deal with three points all relating to specific Questions which have been put on the Paper, but I think that they were the three points which were perhaps most uppermost in the minds of hon. Gentlemen. There are, of course, a number of other issues upon which the House should receive information. These I shall reserve for our debate next week, when Members will have the fullest opportunity of interrogating the Government upon any points of doubt or difference which may exist between us.

I am very much obliged to the House for the patient hearing which they have given me, and I hope that we may now pass to the urgent and most important business of the day.

Mr. C. R. Attlee: As we are to have a debate on Foreign Affairs, I do not want to ask a lot of questions. I should like only to bring out one point which I think

has caused some anxiety. I understand from the right hon. Gentleman that there were no specific agreements further than the general policy that we have been following under both Governments of support for the United Nations and that, in particular, the right hon. Gentleman did not give his support to those unwise Americans who do not take General Bradley's view as to the position of the war in the Far East.

The Prime Minister: I do not wish to add to what I have said. It must be read in conjunction with the very full and measured and comprehensive statement which was made yesterday by the Foreign Secretary.

Mr. Clement Davies: May I ask a question of the right hon. Gentleman on rather an urgent matter dealing with the last part of his statement about Egypt and the Middle East? Has his attention been directed to a report this morning in one of the morning newspapers of a statement made by the new Egyptian Prime Minister that he is ready and willing to continue discussions and even apparently to look favourably upon the Four Power proposals? Perhaps the right hon. Gentleman or the Foreign Secretary can give some information.

The Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs (Mr. Anthony Eden): I have read that report and other reports which are not, I think, inconsistent with anything that I myself said yesterday, but it is my belief that, from the point of view of making progress, I should be wise to say nothing more at the moment.

Mr. Speaker: As we are to have a foreign affairs debate next week and as business is very much in arrear, I think we ought to proceed to the ballot for Notices of Motion.

Mr. S. Silverman: On a point of order. I should like to ask whether one might nevertheless, in spite of what you said, ask one supplementary question on a point of fact which would not properly come into the debate next week?

Mr. Speaker: I am afraid not. We must get on. I hope that the hon. Member will find another method of clearing up his point of fact.

BALLOT FOR NOTICES OF MOTIONS

Employment (Old People)

Mr. Richard Wood: I beg to give notice that on Friday, 8th February, I shall call attention to the desirability of keeping old people in employment, and move a Resolution.

Productivity

Sir Edward Boyle: I beg to give notice that on Friday, 8th February, I shall call attention to the necessity for a rising level of productivity as the only means of achieving full employment and a rising standard of living, and move a Resolution.

Industry (Incentive Payments)

Mr. J. B. Godber: I beg to give notice that on Friday, 8th February, I shall call attention to the desirability of encouraging systems of incentive payment in industry, and move a Resolution.

BILLS PRESENTED

Customs and Excise Bill

"to consolidate with amendments certain enactments relating to customs and excise and to extend certain provisions of those enactments to any other matter in relation to which the Commissioners of Customs and Excise are for the time being required in pursuance of any enactment to perform any duties"; presented by the Chancellor of the Exchequer; supported by the Attorney-General and Mr. Boyd-Carpenter; read the First time; to be read a Second time Tomorrow, and to be printed. [Bill 44.]

Currency and Bank Notes Bill

"to amend the law with respect to the issue and recall of bank notes by the Bank of England"; presented by the Chancellor of the Exchequer; supported by Mr. Boyd-Carpenter; read the First time; to be read a Second time Tomorrow, and to be printed. [Bill 45.]

Agriculture (Fertilisers) Bill

"to authorise the payment out of moneys provided by Parliament of contributions for relief of occupiers of agricultural land in respect of expenditure on

Motion made, and Question proposed, "That this House do now adjourn."—[*Mr. Buchan-Hepburn.*]

FOREIGN AFFAIRS

3.49 p.m.

The Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs (Mr. Anthony Eden): I sincerely hope that I do not embarrass any section of the House by seeking to catch your eye, Mr. Speaker, in order to open the two-day debate on foreign affairs, but there have been——

Mr. Herbert Morrison (Lewisham, South): The Prime Minister has run away.

Mr. Eden: Nobody has run away. The right hon. Gentleman the Member for Lewisham, South (Mr. H. Morrison), must not take his views on such a short run as that; he is likely to be proved wrong before many minutes have passed.

I was about to say, but for the running fire of commentary from the Opposition Front Bench, that I think it is a good idea in general that, as the world scene is so troubled, the Foreign Secretary should open the two-day debate on foreign affairs. When I have been in opposition there have been occasions when I have wished that it should be so and that we should not have to wait until the last phase of the discussion to have a glimmering of an idea of what the Government's foreign policy might be. [*Interruption.*] I am not reproaching the right hon. Gentleman the Member for Lewisham, South, but he really must not be so sensitive so early in our proceedings. There is a long way to go yet. [An HON. MEMBER: "Get on."] I am trying to, if only the Front Bench opposite will let me. We must get more cohesion between the benches opposite.

When we last debated foreign affairs in this House in November of last year, I described the state of the world—not, I must add, at that time thinking of the Opposition benches—as a tangled and troubled scene. I then had had only about a month in which to look round me and get some grasp of the problems which daily crowded in upon us. Since then I have been to Rome, Paris, Washington and Ottawa. I have had the opportunity to talk with other Western statesmen and to discuss our common problems. In the light of this experience, I should like to tell the House how, in my view, we stand today.

I do not intend to ramble over the whole world scene. The House has heard the account given by my right hon. Friend the Prime Minister of our conversations in Washington. I shall have some further comments to make this afternoon on the subject of those conversations; but there are also other problems of urgent importance on which I shall have something to say, and I propose to begin near home with the European scene.

If we take a day-to-day view of what is going on around us, it is inevitable that every difference of opinion looms large before our eyes. There have, of course, been such differences, and I shall be dealing with them in a little detail in a moment. They force themselves more prominently on our attention perhaps than the agreements reached and the progress, unspectacular but steady, which I think has been realised.

Most observers on the Continent, I believe, would agree that, though anxieties remain, the fear of immediate war has not increased and is indeed less. I think that is a fair judgment, and I think many factors have helped to bring it about. I will tell the House what they are. First, the growing strength of the Western nations which, though still relatively modest in conventional arms, becomes more evident every month. Second, the recent Assembly of the United Nations which, though marked by sharp and wordy differences, was, on the whole, less violent in controversy. And this Assembly did in the end agree to start work on a Disarmament Convention. Third, the remarkable progress which has been made towards a European Defence Community and, finally and perhaps most important of all, the work that is being done to widen and reinforce the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation.

If I may recall it to hon. Members, at the December meeting of the North Atlantic Council in Rome the Ministers of the 12 North Atlantic Treaty countries heard an interim report from the Temporary Committee of the Council, prepared by "the three wise men" as they have been called, perhaps not entirely without reason. This Committee was set

[MR. EDEN.]
up to strike a balance between the military requirements and the political and economic resources of the individual countries. It has now completed its examination of the facts. Figures have been submitted by each member State, and the Committee has made specific recommendations for increasing defence efforts in a number of countries—not in ours.

At the forthcoming Council meeting at Lisbon, we shall hear each country's comments on these recommendations. We shall discuss them and consider how far they can be put into effect. At Rome there was also agreement that the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation was still top-heavy. In particular, the long intervals between the Council meetings, the inability of deputies to take far-reaching decisions on behalf of their Governments and the way in which subordinate committees of N.A.T.O., as I suppose we have to call it, are scattered about in many different capitals—all these prevented the Organisation from being as efficient as it should be. A number of proposals for disposing of these difficulties have now been made and are likely to be finally agreed at Lisbon.

The burden of them is that the Council should be in permanent session and that the national representatives on it should have a wider authority. There would also be a strengthened secretariat, particularly in the higher circles, and a permanent headquarters—about the location of which I have certain views which I will not elaborate—and where as many services as possible should be grouped. Of course, the form this Organisation finally takes depends upon decisions to be reached in concert with our Allies.

We hope to be able to welcome representatives of two new members of the Organisation to the Lisbon meeting. The House may recall that on 19th November, I informed hon. Members that His Majesty's Government proposed to declare very soon their formal acceptance of Turkey and Greece into N.A.T.O. Both those countries are old and trusted friends of ourselves, and I am glad to be able to say that we were the first of the N.A.T.O. countries to give formal approval of their admission. It is our hope that the necessary Parliamentary arrangements will have been carried out in the next week or so in order that Greece and Turkey may attend the Lisbon conference as full members.

Let me now turn to the much more difficult question of the function of Western Germany in the community of free nations. Last November, Mr. Acheson, M. Schuman, Dr. Adenauer and I approved, as the House may remember, the draft of a General Agreement. In that we set forth the main principles which were to govern the relations between the three Western Allies and the German Federal Republic. This draft is now being completed with a number of related conventions. These cover in more detail such important matters as the status, protection and support of the Allied Forces stationed in and shielding Germany and the problems which will arise when the Allied High Commission is abolished.

These are very complicated but progress is being made with them. None of these conventions will be signed or published until all are completed. I doubt whether they will be ready in all particulars before the Lisbon meeting. A few important points of special complexity will probably be outstanding at that time. I am now awaiting a final report from the High Commissioners in Germany and when that is received we shall have to decide whether it will be useful to hold any meeting of the four Foreign Ministers here in London before the Lisbon meeting in order further to narrow such differences as remain.

Meanwhile, a meeting between the three Powers is, in any event, to take place here in London on 13th February, when it will be my privilege to welcome Mr. Schuman and Mr. Acheson. I need hardly say I shall be delighted also to invite Dr. Adenauer to join us here if, as I hope, the negotiations have reached a stage which will enable us to hold fruitful talks and take necessary decisions. I should personally welcome an opportunity to see Dr. Adenauer in London again. We all understand his problems and the spirit of European solidarity in which he approaches them.

The French have had a difficult and delicate task to balance, in their country, the dark and painful influences of the past and the growing hopes of the future. Their courage in this endeavour and their

understanding of the similar difficulties which face the Federal German Government, have been decisive contributions to the progress which has been made. Far-reaching events are taking place in Western Europe at this time. The results of the long and complex deliberations which have been held in Bonn and in Paris will soon be made known to the Parliaments and the people of the countries concerned. If they can be agreed—and I believe they will—they will create a new Europe, different from any known since the days of Charlemagne.

Of course, it is inevitable that during this period, this last critical period, special difficulties should arise. We have been reminded of one in the last few days. The Saar, in the recent history of Franco-German relations, has always been a thorny problem. It is important that we should not now get it out of perspective. Under intelligent and patient statesmanship, I have not the least doubt that it can be solved.

I must just recall to the House that the French Government have always stated that they regard the present arrangements in the Saar as temporary and provisional. More than that: they have declared themselves ready to discuss a solution of this problem in advance of any general peace-treaty settlement. That is still the French position, as I know after my visit to Paris. Therefore the door is open to discussion and negotiation.

Furthermore, the French have been at pains to point out that their interest in the Saar is essentially economic. Anybody who has followed the negotiations on the Schuman Plan knows how true that is and how important the Saar is to the general balance of production in that part of Europe. There is, of course, a political problem too, but I am sure it is not beyond the ability of statecraft to solve it.

A number of suggestions have already been canvassed but I think I am wiser not to mention them to the House at this moment. [AN HON. MEMBER: "Why not?"] Because they may be more likely to succeed if I do not canvass them. If the hon. Gentleman will look at the Germans' own statements of what might be a possible solution, and at some of the French statements, he will find there is running through them both a common thread of ideas. We shall do our best to encourage it, and we can do it better without making public speeches about it.

I repeat my conviction that this is a problem which, with patience and goodwill, can be solved. Of course, we can all understand—and hon. Members of this House better than most—the emotions which the future of the Saar raises, both in France and Germany. Those of us who were in this House before the war know that only too well. These emotions need not, and must not, be allowed to disturb the working out of a new and hopeful relationship in Europe.

I come now to an equally difficult task. Almost all Foreign Office topics are difficult these days. The counterpart of any new contractual relationship between Germany and the three Western Powers is the arrangements for a German contribution to Western defence. I must remind the House that it is only a year ago in Brussels that it was agreed that a German contribution should be made to the European Army. That was the decision.

For the last year, a conference has been working in Paris on the plans for the European Defence Community. We were not members of that conference. By a decision of the late Government, we only had an observer there. Perhaps it is unfortunate that we were not in a position to influence the work of the conference. At any rate, though we are not there, these negotiations have made quite remarkable progress. At their last meeting, the six Foreign Ministers disposed of most of the outstanding problems. It is now expected that an agreed report will be ready for our meeting at Lisbon.

If a European Army is to play its full part in strengthening the defence of the North Atlantic area, it must be fitted into the N.A.T.O. framework. That was laid down by the North Atlantic Council at the meeting in Brussels, but it raises also a pretty formidable problem. Five of the countries participating in the European Defence Community are also members of N.A.T.O., with obligations to both organisations. There is no difficulty there. But Germany, although she is to be a member of the European Defence Community, is not a member of N.A.T.O. Yet it is

[MR. EDEN.]

essential that the European Defence Community, including, of course, German forces, should be under General Eisenhower's command, and that the two organisations, N.A.T.O. and E.D.C., despite differences of membership, should work together.

Here is a complicated task, a really complicated task, for diplomacy, and an intricate piece of machinery to work out. None the less, I am confident that it can be done. I hope that the House has seen the contradiction that Chancellor Adenauer has issued this morning of a most alarming report which appeared in the Press today. We shall go through some very difficult weeks while the Parliaments of France and Germany face this really historic decision. During this time we can help by patience and understanding, and not by alarmist endorsement of every rocking of the boat. That is our task. If we do that, I believe that we can produce a conclusion of which the House and the nation will approve.

What is our country's position in relation to this European Defence Community? Quite a lot has been said about that in the last few months, and it has led to a good deal of discussion and some misunderstanding. It is now clear where we stand and what we should do. I hope it is agreed in all parts of the House, but we shall no doubt find out as the debate goes on. It is our intention to establish a permanent delegation at the seat of the High Authority for coal and steel and to enter into relations and try to transact business with them. That is under the Schuman Plan. It is also our intention to associate ourselves as closely as possible with the European Defence Community in all stages of its political and military development.

We cannot tell yet the exact form our relationship will take, because the European Defence Community has not finally set up its machinery. But I should like to give the House certain indications of what we are prepared to do and see whether we can get a measure of agreement upon them. These are the things we think we should do in respect of the European Defence Community: First, we hope that the United Kingdom and the Community—I wish I could call it an army, but it is more than an army; I do not like the word "community"—will maintain close consultation on problems of common interests and that a suitable means of liaison for this purpose will be established.

Subject to the overriding requirements of the Supreme Allied Commander in Europe, British forces on the Continent will operate as closely as possible with the European defence forces and be linked with them in matters of training, administration and supplies. Arrangements could, for instance, be made for individuals and formations of the European Defence Community to train with British formations in Germany and elsewhere, and for us to lend officers and units where this is convenient to the European Army. We think that a considerable measure of blending between the air forces of the United Kingdom and of Europe may well prove to be a particularly profitable field of action.

There is one thing I must make plain. Let it be clearly understood that we in this island are resolved to maintain armed forces on the continent of Europe for as long as is necessary. We shall do that not only because of the requirements of the European Defence Community, but because of our own obligations under the North Atlantic Treaty and because of our special responsibilities in and to Germany. British forces are, of course, ranged alongside American and European forces in the defence of Western Europe. The measures that I have indicated will contribute to our even closer comradeship. It remains for us to achieve this same unity of purpose and effort in every sphere of N.A.T.O.'s activities.

I should like at this point to remind the House of a recent statement made by General Eisenhower. After saying that he could see no acceptable alternative to union between the States of Europe, he added that he believed that any attempt to include Britain immediately in a European defence force "would be a stumbling block rather than a help." In the same speech he asked how the British Commonwealth of Nations could be combined with Western Europe today. It seems to us that the answer to the question is that, as things have now developed, Britain and the Commonwealth could best be linked with Western Europe through the Atlantic Organisation.

That is why it seems to us of capital importance that we should realise that the North Atlantic Treaty is not merely some temporary expedient arising from the threat of Soviet aggression. That is why we regard it as a permanent association, which must be intimate but not exclusive. Our other Commonwealth ties are sacred.

It sets the pattern, a pattern woven on the wide spread of the Atlantic, for the future of political life in the free world. I hope that in the political field this sense of the Atlantic approach to international problems is going to grow, because it is in that spirit and mood that we can do our own best work. I hope it will be possible for this North Atlantic Council to meet as a forum where Foreign Ministers can discuss matters of foreign policy frankly and in a practical spirit with the hope of enduring success, and not with 400 people round a table in what is called a secret session. I believe that the interest of Parliaments and the public in the Atlantic community should be encouraged by every means in our power. That is a task in which everyone can play a part.

This week the United Nations Assembly adjourns. Nothing gave me greater pleasure than when I heard in Paris at the weekend—I was there meeting French Ministers and members of the United Nations—the warmest possible tributes from those in a position to judge about the work which my right hon. and learned Friend the Minister of State has done. He will deal in greater detail later tonight with the work of the Assembly, and no doubt will be cross-examined upon it by his predecessor. That is as it should be.

At this stage I will refer only to certain impressions I gained of the work of this Paris session. Despite some highly controversial moments, such as this House is now becoming increasingly used to, the course of the discussions in Paris on the whole has been more reasonable and less vituperative than in recent years, and I think that that is all to the good. The Assembly has debated one question of vital interest, namely, disarmament. I would not wish to forecast the results of the work of the new Commission which has now been set up to deal with this subject, but I will say that it is gratifying that it was possible to establish this Commission, and also I think gratifying that Mr. Vyshinsky has indicated that the Soviet Government are prepared to participate in its work. Let us see where we can go in that way.

I now leave European matters and ask the House to consider for a few moments with me the situation in Egypt. The details of the recent events in Cairo, which the world has learned of since I last spoke to the House on this subject about a week ago, show how brutal was the character and how terrible the scale of the destruction of life and property in Cairo 10 days ago. For centuries there can have been no scene like this in a civilised capital in time of peace. Tragic indeed it is that Egypt, one of the most ancient homes of civilisation and history, should be the witness of such events.

In my statement to the House a few days ago, I gave an account of our views and purpose towards Egypt and I have little this afternoon to add to that statement. We are absolutely sincere in our desire to reach an agreement with Egypt which will ensure the security of the Middle East and of the Suez Council. This is an international responsibility. Such an agreement, if it is to have any chance of lasting value, must also take into account the true and rightful aspirations of the Egyptian people. We are prepared to seek ways and means towards this end and to pursue them in a spirit which will give expression to real friendship between our two countries. I am sure that our mutual needs and interests can be reconciled in a way that is both advantageous and honourable to both parties. I still believe that the answer is to be found in an arrangement between us, where the thought is not how much can each get out of the other, but how can we best help each other.

It is in this spirit that I have noted the new Egyptian Prime Minister's public assurances that he wishes to resume negotiations with us. I do not under-rate the difficulties. There are plenty of them ahead, but I hope that the House will understand that I think it will be undesirable for me to be more explicit about our intentions and methods at this stage. I hope the House will need no assurance that I understand how much is at stake in these negotiations both to

[MR. EDEN.]
Egypt and to ourselves. We shall spare no effort to reach an agreement and to reach a settlement which takes account of the legitimate rights of both parties.

Mr. Aneurin Bevan (Ebbw Vale): Before the right hon. Gentleman leaves the Egyptian question, may I interrupt him? As he says, the defence of the Suez Canal is an international obligation. How, therefore, does he propose to invoke international discussion in order that there shall be international defence of the Canal Zone and not bring British troops alone into collision with the Egyptian civil population?

Mr. Eden: I think the best way to handle this affair in the first instance is between ourselves and the Egyptians because it is on the basis of the Anglo-Egyptian Treaty that our forces are in the Canal Zone. Of course I accept, and have always accepted, that the 1936 Treaty can be and should be replaced by some further agreement and that further agreement should be—I hope will be—upon an international basis.

Mr. Bevan: This is an exceedingly important matter and all I want to do is to elicit the facts at this stage so that we can have an intelligent discussion on it later on. The right hon. Gentleman, on the one side, says—and everybody, I think, agrees with him—that this is an international obligation, but then he at once proceeds, as far as I can see, to the only practical steps on a unilateral basis. I should like to ask him, or the Prime Minister if he is to speak tomorrow, whether he will outline in detail how we are to call into existence an international authority to defend the Canal Zone and not place the whole obligation on British troops?

Mr. Eden: I think the position is really clear—[*Interruption.*] I am not trying to score a debating point; this is very serious. In the first instance, we are in the Canal Zone on the basis of the Treaty of 1936. There it is, an Anglo-Egyptian arrangement, and our troops are there on the basis of that Treaty, which the Egyptians have unilaterally renounced. We cannot accept unilateral renunciation of it. We think it better to resume efforts on an Anglo-Egyptian basis because this is an Anglo-Egyptian problem. That is agreed between the Egyptians and ourselves, and, so far as I know, by every other Power in the world.

Mr. E. Shinwell (Easington) *rose—*

Mr. Eden: If the right hon. Gentleman will allow me—I cannot speak all the thoughts in my mind in one sentence. As I say, the first approach should be with the Egyptian Government, and then with others, including the Americans. The first talk should be between us and the Egyptian Government; of course it must be, on the basis of the Egyptian Treaty.

Mr. Shinwell *indicated dissent.*

Mr. Eden: I am sorry the right hon. Gentleman does not see it. If he does not see it, I cannot help that. I am trying to develop a serious argument on a serious subject. When the Anglo-Egyptian discussions have opened, then we are perfectly ready that they should be broadened on to the basis of Four-Power discussions, but, if I may put it to the right hon. Gentleman—and I want the House to consider this—it does not necessarily follow that the Egyptians would most like a Four-Power basis of discussion as the first approach. That is why in all this business, as the House will have seen if it has watched what I have tried to do, I have left the position open so that we can get Four-Power discussions opened if that be the best means of making some further progress ourselves towards further international agreement.

Before I leave that topic, there is a much more difficult one—[*Interruption.*] —I am always glad of agreement wherever I can find it. There is a topic of the first importance to which I must refer before I leave the Egyptian scene. I cannot leave this question without a reference to the Sudan. Last November I made a statement to this House which I think received general endorsement. As I said then, and I say now, I am sincerely anxious to reach agreement with Egypt: but I can take no step which would be a betrayal of the pledges which that statement contained. Therefore, while I am very ready to search for a solution, there will be no going back on those pledges—which, perhaps, does not facilitate my task.

Now I turn to another country about which I have very little that is encouraging to report to the House—developments

in Persia. The Persian Government's initial response at the beginning of last month to the International Bank's initiative was hardly encouraging. Nevertheless, I understand the Bank has continued in its efforts and is determined to see what contribution it can make to end the present deadlock, a deadlock which leaves the great oil industry idle and unproductive. A week or two back, Dr. Mossadeq told Sir Francis Shepherd, when he was leaving Teheran, that he did not know why the British Government had not concluded a matter which could be concluded with ease and goodwill and why this difference between the two Governments still remained.

I confess that I found this statement somewhat baffling. It has to be set against the action of the Persian Government in closing our consulates in Persia and refusing to accept our new Ambassador, the distinguished son of a distinguished father. The Persian Prime Minister's claim that our consular representatives have been improperly interfering in the internal affairs of his country is utterly unfounded. No evidence has been brought forward which possibly could justify the action. It may be, however, that the move was inspired, not by external considerations, but by internal politics, which, I understand, are somewhat involved in Persia at this time.

As for the appointment of a new Ambassador, the Persian Government have announced that they will not accept diplomats who have previously served in Persia and, although they have nothing against Mr. Hankey personally, they could not accept him on this account, that is to say, that he had previously served in Persia. Another complaint I have heard is that he speaks Persian. This will seem to many people rather an odd basis for refusing a foreign representative, but, if it becomes at all a general habit, it will certainly simplify the Foreign Office examination. In the circumstances, what are His Majesty's Government to do? We do not at present propose to appoint another Ambassador and, despite all the discouragement, we shall continue to work to bring about that improvement in relations which the Persian Prime Minister reiterates he desires.

There has recently been, at the United Nations and elsewhere, much dispute and many allegations about the presence in the Kengtung Province of Burma of a number of Chinese Nationalist troops. Soviet charges that these troops were being assisted by the United States have been categorically denied, both by Mr. Acheson and United States representatives in the First Committee of the United Nations Assembly in the last few days.

We all know that some Kuomintang troops took refuge in Burma in the closing stages of the Chinese Civil War. What has happened since then has been obscured by conflicting reports and, it may be, by deliberate distortion, also. It is, however, clear that Chinese Nationalist troops are on Burmese soil and that they constitute a problem for the Burmese Government, who have not been able to secure their disarmament. His Majesty's Government are ready to do all they can to clear up this confused and disturbing situation. As it seems to us, the first task must be to establish the facts and then to consider what should be the best way of dealing with them.

There are a number of ways in which this might be done. It might, for instance, be helpful if the United Nations could establish a small commission to investigate this situation. If this were generally thought to be a practical proposal and the Burmese Government were agreeable, we should be willing to try to help it forward. That is all I should like to say on that topic at this time.

Mr. Woodrow Wyatt (Birmingham, Aston): In the meantime, will the right hon. Gentleman impress upon Americans the enormous importance of preventing not only their officials but their "unofficials" from carrying arms or any sort of supplies to the Kuomintang troops in Burma from Formosa?

Mr. Eden: I do not think the hon. Gentleman's contribution is a particularly helpful one. What I was trying to suggest is that we all know there is a dispute about the facts of this matter. I thought it best that the proposal which I made, and which I purposely put delicately because there are lots of other things to consider in this matter—not only the position of America but the position of the

[MR. EDEN.]

Burmese Government and some others—should be only a suggestion that this commission would be useful and we should do our best to bring it about. I think I should be rather wise to leave it at that.

Mr. Sydney Silverman (Nelson and Colne): I quite understand and that the right hon. Gentleman might not be able to answer this point but, in case he can, is it his idea that in any international investigation the Chinese Government that we recognise might be associated with that inquiry in some way?

Mr. Eden: I have only sought to help on the inquiry. It is clearly a difficult arrangement. I do not know whether it would be welcome even to the Burmese Government. If one gets an international situation which is causing concern, someone has to make a move of some sort and we can be sure the move will be unpopular with certain Governments. I thought it best to make the move in this House, in this way but I was careful not to say anything about the composition.

On the Far East situation I will conclude by turning to the vexing question of Japan's relations with Formosa. From the moment when this problem was drawn to my attention in the Foreign Office, it has always been my view that the nature of Japan's relations with China should be left for Japan to decide after she had regained her full sovereignty. I have held—and hold—this view for many reasons, one of which is that I consider it of importance that during the occupation Japan should not commit herself to policies for which, if they later turn out to be ill-advised, she would blame the occupying Powers.

I have expressed that view on several occasions—in Tokio and Washington—and there has never been the least doubt about its being our opinion, as I think it was the opinion of the previous Government. I am quite sure that the United States Government would be perfectly ready to state publicly, if they were asked, that they know this to be so; indeed, Senator Sparkman, who accompanied Mr. Dulles to Japan last December, has, since his return, spoken of this matter with commendable frankness. In referring to Mr. Yoshida's action in writing his letter, he said: "We know that this did not accord with the wishes of Great Britain."

This is an issue upon which it must be openly admitted that we and the United States Government have not been in agreement. I am sorry about it, but I do not think it could have been avoided. As regards Japanese-Chinese relations, only time will show whether the Japanese Government are acting wisely. In my view it would have been better if their hand had remained free.

Mr. Ellis Smith (Stoke-on-Trent, South): Before the Foreign Secretary leaves that question, does that mean to say that while he and the Prime Minister were in America no change was made from our previous position?

Mr. Eden: Our view about this matter has been expressed on many occasions ever since I took over the Foreign Office. I know it was in harmony with the view previously expressed by the late Government; but it is fair to say to the late Government that I did not form my view because it had been theirs before.

Now I turn to the Korean issue. There has been much interest and speculation whether, in our talks in Washington, we entered into any new commitments in regard to Korea. The answer is that we entered into no new commitments. As there has been so much misunderstanding on the subject, however, I should like to add a few words of explanation.

When a situation as dangerous as the Korean war exists, it is natural and right that His Majesty's Government and other Governments should be constantly looking into the future and thinking of the various situations which might develop and the various courses of action which they might require. In this way, at this stage of the Korean war, we have for some time been considering, in consultation principally with the United States Government and the Governments of the Commonwealth and other members of the United Nations, what should be our policy in the event, first, of an armistice being concluded in Korea, and secondly, of a resumption of fighting without an armistice.

On the first hypothesis—an armistice—two different things might happen. An armistice might be loyally observed and might be followed by discussions for a political settlement in Korea and a general relaxation of tension in the Far East. This is a contingency which we all

hope to see realised and for which, under the United Nations, we are constantly working.

But we have also to consider the possibility of an armistice being violated by a further act of armed aggression in Korea. As my right hon. Friend the Prime Minister explained in the House last week, this would create a very grave situation, the consequences of which have been fully examined, but without our entering into any definite or formal commitments. The only undertaking, if it can be so described —and I leave that to the House to judge —which we have entered into is that in that event, that is to say, a breach of an armistice, consultations would take place amongst the interested Powers, including ourselves. I am quite confident that this is also the view of the American Government in the present position.

There is another main contingency which has necessarily been under consideration, and that is that the armistice talks might finally break down—which is the other aspect of the matter—and that heavy fighting might be resumed in Korea. The Press on both sides of the Atlantic have been trying to guess our plans in this event, and no doubt our enemies in Korea have been trying to guess them, too—and I hope we can continue to keep them guessing.

But the fact that we have been considering various unpleasant possibilities does not mean that we want or expect them to happen ; nor have His Majesty's Government entered into any new commitments regarding the contingencies which might then arise. I hope that is clear. We shall continue to plan and to prepare ourselves for any foreseeable turn in events, while continuing to work for the peaceful and just settlement which we all so earnestly desire. Fortunately, the prospects of this are, today, definitely brighter.

If I am to judge by the criticism, there seems to be an impression in some quarters in this country—and this, I think, is at the heart of the matter—that the United States is not really sincere in its pursuit of the armistice negotiations——

Mr. S. O. Davies (Merthyr Tydvil): A very strong impression.

Mr. Eden : I am glad to deal with it—and even that she seeks an extension of the conflict in the Far East. I want to state my experience, that I heard no single word in any responsible quarter, while I was in America, to lend colour to this belief. I sincerely believe that the American Government and people—both of them—are as deeply anxious for peace in the Far East as we are ourselves.

Mr. Ellis Smith : The American Press do not say that.

Mr. Eden : The hon. Gentleman knows that in a vast free country of 150 million people Press quotations can always be found to support any point of view. That is so here, after all, despite the shortage of newsprint, and there is no shortage of newsprint there. We really must not allow ourselves to be influenced by some alarmist and extremist views. Of course, they exist in every free country. The only place where they do not exist is in totalitarian countries, where they are not allowed to.

This is the crux of what is troubling the public and House here and I want to tell the House why the Americans are, if possible, more anxious than we are to get an armistice: because they have felt and do feel the impact of their casualties upon their ordinary life at home—100,000. They affect every small town in the United States and have brought sorrow and anxiety to many American homes. They feel, too, that they have carried the main burden of the Korean conflict on behalf of the United Nations.

That is what they think. Hon. Gentlemen here may not all share that view but that is their conviction and I think that in it they are fully justified. That is why they are impatient and intolerant when others turn to lecture them and say " Why do you not take this or that particular attitude? " We have to use a more vivid imagination here to get across the Atlantic scene if we want to understand each other. I am as sure as I stand here that there is a deep and lasting American desire to reach a solution of this Korean conflict.

Mr. R. H. S. Crossman (Coventry, East): While accepting what the right hon. Gentleman says about Press and public opinion, what is his view of the statements by the Secretary of State for the Navy and by Admiral Fechteler last week that in the event of an armistice not being achieved, war would be taken

[MR. CROSSMAN.]
to the Chinese coast? This was being said after the right hon. Gentleman had been in Washington, and it made some of us alarmed. This is not the Press; this is one member of the Administration and one senior official of the Navy.

Mr. Eden: I have not the details of the statements. [HON. MEMBERS: "Oh."] What is the use of saying "Oh." I do not carry around with me notes of what every American says. If the hon. Gentleman wished to raise anything about that, I would naturally have looked up those statements if I had had notice.

Mr. James Hudson (Ealing, North): We have all noticed them.

Mr. Eden: I think the House is being a little unreasonable. I have given what I believe to be the broad American opinion. Individual speeches of this character are often made. I cannot reply for the American Administration; I can reply only for His Majesty's Government. If statements of that kind have been made, they do not in any sense represent the policy of His Majesty's Government. I cannot answer for the American Government.

Mr. Crossman: The right hon. Gentleman stated that he had found no trace of the alarmist views which some of us brought back. I quoted to him not from Mr. Henry Luce but from the Secretary of State for the Navy and Admiral Fechteler. I am really amazed that the right hon. Gentleman says that he has not had time to notice that since he and his right hon. Friend came back from Washington these two really responsible people have put forward what the right hon. Gentleman describes as alarmist views for which there was no foundation in his experience. These are the facts. Surely the right hon. Gentleman must take cognisance of them.

Mr. Eden: I accept what the hon. Member says. All I can say is that in my experience, and I have checked this as best I can with our authorities in the United States, I did not and my right hon. Friend did not hear any statements of that kind made to us. [*Laughter.*] I do not know why hon. Members should laugh at that. I am trying to give the House a fair impression of what my right hon. Friend and I heard. In some quarters there is such anti-American prejudice that they will hardly listen to—[*Interruption.*] All I can deal with is what was said to us in our conversations.

I repeat that nothing remotely resembling those two quotations—my right hon. Friend will bear me out—was said to us in the course of any discussions which we had. It was exactly the opposite. President Truman, Mr. Acheson, General Bradley and all the others took exactly the opposite view. The hon. Member knows quite well that American ideas of Cabinet responsibility, their whole system, are different from our own. I am only saying what was said to us.

I repeat my impression, and I hope that history will prove me right within a week or a fortnight, that they want an armistice, that it will be signed and that it will be good. But the hon. Member and others are always trying to make bad blood between us and the Americans.

Mr. Crossman: The right hon. Gentleman has twice made the allegation that those asking the question I did were inspired by anti-American feeling. I should like to say, first, that I did not say that they do not want an armistice, nor did Admiral Fechteler or the Secretary of State for the Navy. They were discussing the right hon. Gentleman's second hypothesis. I was pointing out to him that the view which he says he did not find in Washington was in fact expressed by two men very close to the President. I say to the right hon. Gentleman that he has no right to call anybody anti-American for stating facts.

Mr. Eden: If I became slightly exasperated, that was not my intention, but I do feel very deeply on this topic. [HON. MEMBERS: "So do we."] Yes, that is why we are discussing it. I genuinely believe that there is a measure of misunderstanding here of the American attitude in these matters. When the hon. Member said that these were the views about what was to happen if an armistice should be broken——

Mr. Crossman: No, if it does not occur.

Mr. Eden: As far as an armistice not occurring is concerned, I can only tell the hon. Member that our views of that are precisely the same as those of the

previous Government here. Our position is precisely that declared by the Government before. On that there is no shadow of dispute. If the hon. Gentleman wants more details, they should not be asked of us.

Mrs. Barbara Castle (Blackburn, East): The remark which the right hon. Gentleman has just made is very important. I have been following as closely as I could, and earlier it seemed to me that there was much greater dubiety in what he said to the effect that if the third alternative occurs—the breakdown of the talks—we do not propose to let our enemy in Korea know what we intend to do. Now he has just told us that if that third contingency arises, his view is the same as that of the Opposition.

Can we take it that he does support our view—[*Interruption.*] We all hope that there is an armistice, but in the view of many of us the real danger will come, not if there is an armistice, but if the armistice talks break down. In that event, is it the right hon. Gentleman's assurance to the House that it is not the view of His Majesty's Government that the war should then be extended to the Chinese mainland?

Mr. Eden: I think there are two different hypotheses. I tried to explain them clearly. One is if an armistice is not reached and the conflict is renewed. It is in respect of that that the hon. Gentleman gave his quotation. In respect of that situation, we are in the same position as the previous Government.

There is the second position as to what would happen if an armistice is signed and then broken. In my opinion, that is not the most likely hypothesis, but should it happen we are committed certainly to consultation as to the action to be taken. If the hon. Lady will look at my speech tomorrow, she will not have to worry herself unduly. I think it is all right—at least, I know it is all right—but I hope I have made it plain that it is all right.

There is another aspect of American opinion which I want to put to the House—I believe it is true that America understands this as well—that is, that Europe is still the decisive area. Indeed, none of us can afford to forget that it is here in Europe that the Communist empire marches with the Western world. Certainly the United States, in my conviction, have no desire to become more deeply involved in the Far East.

May I give one final illustration? Two days ago our two Governments introduced a resolution in the United Nations which secured the largest majority ever obtained since the Korean conflict began. That was to do all we could to help the negotiations at Panmunjom and to try to bring to a conclusion an armistice in Korea. That was passed, as I say, in the appropriate committee by the largest majority it has ever had. That ensures that if an armistice is secured there shall be a special session of the General Assembly to consider the political issues which will have to be dealt with.

Here, I submit, is a policy for any Government which earnestly desires to bring to an end this wasteful war in Korea. It is the policy of His Majesty's Government; it is the policy of the United States Government, and the policy of the United Nations.

So we are continuing in every sphere our efforts towards our aim for a world settlement, a state of peace in which we can turn our resources to more constructive tasks. The progress we have made—and I am sure it is real progress—owes much to the fact that not only have we worked in unity with loyal allies, but here at home party differences on these issues have, at least in the past, dissolved in the unity of common purpose and determination. Our first responsibility to the people of this country, and indeed to the whole world, is to play our full part of leadership in the cause of peace.

The wider our own measure of unity, the greater our influence in the world. Nothing is more elusive than to try to consolidate peace, yet in the last few months in at least three areas, in Korea, in Egypt and in Western Europe, the prospects are today more hopeful. Can we in one or all of these theatres relax tension and build understanding? I believe we can, and I also believe that success of this kind can lead to wider understanding. That is what we seek to do. We ask this House to help us in our task.

4.54 p.m.

Mr. C. R. Attlee (Walthamstow, West): We have heard an interesting speech by the Foreign Secretary, though I do not think that he told us much which was new. He struck a welcome note of hopefulness, but on most of the topics on which he spoke he said there were difficulties; he hoped the difficulties would be overcome; and that left us very much in the same position as when he last spoke. In fact, I think one would hardly have called for a Foreign Affairs debate of two days if it was merely on the kind of statement that the Foreign Secretary has made to us.

But the desire for this debate was occasioned by statements made by the Prime Minister in the course of his American visit, and I regret that he has not seen fit to open this debate. After all, he paid a visit, a very much publicised visit, to the United States; a very important visit. He made a speech to Congress, and the limelight was all on the Prime Minister, and not on the Foreign Secretary.

On coming back he made a short statement last week which, we understood, was to be amplified. The general opinion about that statement is this, that everyone was struck by the difference of tone of the statement which he made in this House and the speech which he made to Congress. The "New York Times" on 31st January, said:

> "Prime Minister Churchill gave a good demonstration of how to say the same thing in two different ways . . . like a good salesman with different customers he displayed his wares to their best advantage, first in Washington and then in London."

But the question we are asking is whether they were the same wares. It may be good salesmanship, but I do not think it is good statesmanship.

The right hon. Gentleman made two statements on the same matter which are interpreted differently in two different countries, although the entire object of the visit was to try to promote mutual understanding. There is no doubt about it that that was the impression given in the United States. The speech made by the Prime Minister was interpreted as being a sharp change in policy.

> "'Prompt, resolute and effective action' was widely interpreted here"—

says an American writer—

> "as a willingness to join the United States in such measures as bombing Manchurian airfields and blockading Communist China. The Labour Party Opposition in Britain also construed the pledge in the same way."

And not only, I may say, the Labour Opposition. It goes on:

> "They were told yesterday that while it was agreed that a violation of a truce would lead to a very serious situation there had been no definite or formal commitment."

Now we ought to know here whether there has been this definite change of attitude. The "New York Herald-Tribune" says:

> "Britain will lend full support to that kind of direct attack on Chinese centres of strength which Britain so much opposed when MacArthur advocated the idea."

The "Kansas City Star" described that as:

> "a notable shift in the position."

The result was that there has been grave disquietude here over the speech of the Prime Minister.

When the right hon. Gentleman comes back here he makes a speech in an entirely different key, and tells us there has been no change whatever. The question is: Is this only a change of salesmanship methods, or is there a difference? I am bound to say that, reading his speech, the general attitude struck me as one that he was, quite naturally, trying to please his audience. But I cannot but think that in doing so he tended to represent us as an ally, even a comparative minor ally, in an American war.

It is significant that he only mentioned the United Nations once in the whole of that speech, and that was only very much in passing mainly to emphasise the fact that physical action was being taken on the largest scale by the United States for a moral action of the United Nations. Thereafter, with that passing glance at the United Nations, it got no more reference at all.

One might have thought that this was purely a quarrel between the United States of America and the Communist Government of China. That was an unfortunate impression to give. Then the Prime Minister said, "We take our stand at your side." That is all very well, but we were taking our stand also at the side of other nations. The stand we were taking was on behalf of the United

Nations with other nations. Here again, the emphasis was wrong. When they came to discuss what the next step should be it looked almost as if the decision should be that the United States and we should agree; and the question of the fact of this being action taken by the United States and other nations on behalf of the United Nations entirely slips out of the picture.

Therefore, we want to know just what the attitude of the Prime Minister really was on these matters when they came to discuss them and not merely when he was addressing Congress. It seemed to me curious that in all these discussions the whole emphasis seemed to be on the contingency of the armistice being broken. I am quite sure that the Americans all want the armistice to succeed, as we do. But there was very little emphasis——

The Prime Minister (Mr. Winston Churchill): What about your followers?

Mr. Attlee: —but the Prime Minister put very little emphasis on the armistice succeeding. In the Congress speech, in his speech here and in the speech of the Foreign Secretary, not one word was said as to what was to happen in the way of going further than the armistice when the armistice has succeeded.

Mr. Eden: I did elaborate that. I said that the United Nations passed a resolution two days ago, on our initiative, as to what we should do if the armistice was agreed.

Mr. Attlee: It has not been considered in the least. We have had no discussion at all, as far as I can make out, of how we are to get peace in the Far East when we have got an armistice. An armistice is only the first step.

Mr. Eden: If I may speak again—I know that I have said too much—there was a resolution moved only two days ago at the United Nations by us and the United States as to the exact procedure we should take if an armistice was reached.

Mr. Attlee: I am not talking of procedure: I am talking of policy. This is a very important matter. When I went to America we discussed this policy and we found certain differences which have to be thrashed out. The trouble is that there is only one point that was touched on by the Prime Minister in his Congress speech—and I think it unfortunate that he mentioned it—and that was Formosa.

The Prime Minister went out of his way to deal with the most difficult point of the whole question of a Far Eastern settlement in order to say what we had all agreed—that these people under Chiang Kai-shek should not be left to be massacred.

The Prime Minister: You agree on that, do you?

Mr. Attlee: I do. I have said so. But the obvious interpretation on his words—the whole slant of his words—was support for the Chiang Kai-shek régime to save Formosa. I am perfectly well aware of the importance of the Formosa question. The Americans necessarily feel very sensitive about Formosa, because it was through Formosa that the attack was launched in the last war; but the Chinese also feel very sensitive about Formosa.

The Prime Minister: The Chinese Communists.

Mr. Attlee: The Government of China. They see here a Government that has been turned out of China, which I believe is a Government completely discredited. They see it there situated within striking distance, and it is perfectly natural to think that it is being held there as a spear-head of a possible attack against them.

Mr. Ellis Smith: Like Kolckak.

Mr. Attlee: There is obviously a danger from the point of view of the Chinese. What is to be done about Formosa is a vital question in any settlement. I have not advocated handing Formosa and all those people there to the Chinese Government, but I also do not believe in maintaining Formosa as a point of arms for a rival Chinese Government.

For myself, I believe that the right thing is that this place should be neutralised for a period of years. But we have to face up to this. The fact is —the right hon. Gentleman may not have intended it—that the general reaction to his statement was a backing of the Chiang Kai-shek Government. I believe that the continued backing of the

[MR. ATTLEE.]
Chiang Kai-shek Government is fatal to getting a settlement in the Far East. That is the obvious interpretation that was given and taken.

The Prime Minister: The right hon. Gentleman has said that on the particular statement made—that the Chinese Nationalist refugees on the Island of Formosa should not be allowed to be massacred by an expedition across the sea from the mainland—we were agreed. Have I said anything else on the subject?

Mr. Attlee: No. But the mere fact that that was dragged into the speech—[*Laughter.*] It is no good laughing. Even the Minister of State will find that when he makes speeches on Foreign Affairs he has to be very careful about what he says, because not only what he says but the impression given is most important.

That undoubtedly was the impression. I think that it was a most unwise suggestion. The right hon. Gentleman the Foreign Secretary said, rightly, that the Administration wanted an armistice. Then he proceeded rather to suggest that the whole of the country necessarily thought just as the Administration did. I was under the impression, certainly when I was there, that there was a party that was for an all-out war against China. Undoubtedly, there were people who wanted what they call drastic action under MacArthur. Undoubtedly, there are forces today in America which would like to have what they call a "showdown" with the Communists.

Miss Jennie Lee (Cannock): And that is not being anti-American.

Mr. Attlee: That is the fact. There are those various currents of opinion in the United States of America. It is most important to do everything to support the people who want an armistice and who believe in limiting this war, and not to give any occasion to think that there is any support whatever for the people who take the other view.

Among our people there are various sections. There are the violent anti-Communists, and then there are the impatient people who say, "Let us get it cleared up." There are people who have their eyes more on the East than on the West. There is that danger that we might be dragged into a war which nobody wishes, and, as was said on the other side and has been said by the Prime Minister—I think we have all said it—it would be a great strategic mistake to get bogged down in a China war.

There, again, we have to be careful in our speeches not to lend support to those people whose minds are turned in that direction. There are wise people in the United States, but that was the general impression that was given over here; the right hon. Gentleman explained it, and he also said that they had discussed various matters, but he could not say anything more.

I quite agree that we cannot tell our opponents everything we are going to do in a matter of this kind, but the Prime Minister must see that that kind of statement has added to the suspicions which many people have that we were being committed more deeply than appeared on the surface. Therefore, I think it would have been well if the Prime Minister had made a speech today in which he dealt with this matter, because he must know of the existence of this criticism. He must have known that the newspapers have said that he speaks with two voices, and it is just as well, here in this House, that we should have but one voice—a single voice not to be interpreted one way on one side of the Atlantic and in another way on the other.

The Prime Minister: It will be a very great help to me tomorrow to have these points so shrewdly and moderately put before me by the right hon. Gentleman, so that I can rescue him from any anxiety he may have. I might, perhaps, show him that the differences between us are not so wide as he supposes.

Mr. Attlee: I should have thought that the Prime Minister would have liked to clear it up himself, and not to have it dragged out of him. I hope that there is a general agreement on the need for doing our utmost, first of all, to get an armistice, and, secondly, in any event, to try to limit the contest in the Far East.

I think we should not lend ourselves to the kind of suggestion such as that of a blockade of China—a perfectly futile operation—or to any extension of the war, and all that kind of talk that goes

on. I think it is up to us to be a steadying influence here which will help the Administration in the United States of America.

The Foreign Secretary covered a good deal of ground, and he gave us a good deal of cause for hope, but I do not think he opened up anything very new. There seems to be a relaxation of tension, and we all hope that talks will soon begin with the Egyptian Government with a view to trying to get a settlement there.

I hope, too, that we shall see something more reasonable come out of Persia. I could not help noticing that the fact that the Persian Government had refused to receive a British Ambassador caused no emotion on the Conservative benches. If that had happened in the time of the Labour Government, we should have been told, "They are kicking you all round the place," but, with the situation as it is now, it does not matter. That goes for a good many of these things——

The Prime Minister: After being kicked out of Abadan, as we were, the refusal of the Persians to receive a British Ambassador is quite a minor matter.

Mr. Attlee: I did not think that it was the official view of the Conservatives that we should have stayed in Abadan by force. [HON. MEMBERS: "Answer."] Perhaps we had better not debate that point.

There is only one other point with which I should like to deal, and that concerns the negotiations that are going forward for building up the defences of Western Europe. It is difficult to follow exactly what is happening in the building up of the European Army. We have taken the line that that is the most hopeful way of bringing in German Forces for the defence of Western Europe, including Germany, but we have seen a certain slipping, and we believe that, while it is essential and right for the defence of Western Europe that there should be participation by German Forces, there must be the greatest care to see that we do not again build up militarist forces in Germany.

Therefore, we have held that there should not be anything which would be building up a new German Army. I noted that the Prime Minister did use the phrase "German Army," but perhaps that was merely a slip. We held, too, that the Forces of the Western Powers should be armed and strengthened first before there is an attempt to bring in German units. I entirely agree with what was said with regard to our association with the defence of the West, but without our complete integration in an army of that kind, and I was pleased to hear about the work of the air Forces, although that joint training had already taken place in the time of the late Government. I think we want to have the greatest degree of co-operation both between ourselves and the Forces of the United States and the European Army under the aegis of N.A.T.O., but I think that there we shall require a great deal of flexibility.

On the other points touched on by the Foreign Secretary, I was pleased to find that there seemed to be a reasonable optimism, but I have not dealt with them at any great length, because perhaps some of my colleagues will deal with them, if it is thought to be necessary, and because this debate was specifically brought forward so that we might clear up this matter of what really happened on the Prime Minister's visit to the United States.

Let me say that there is nothing I dislike more than the kind of stupid anti-Americanism which one can find in people of various kinds in this country. [HON. MEMBERS: "Over there."] Yes, and over there, too. There is nothing so bad as trying to make bad blood between our two countries. It is done sometimes by people who suggest that, in all our foreign policy, we meekly follow America, and it is done sometimes by other people who suggest that we are, economically, entirely dependent on America—a mere dependant. They are both wrong.

This country holds its own position in the world, and it is vital that we should not be regarded as a mere tool of any other country. The British Commonwealth has its own position in the world, to maintain its independence, with its allies, and anybody who, in any way, seeks to stir up bad blood between the British peoples and the Americans, or indeed between us and any of the other democratic forces, is doing a bad service to the cause of world peace.